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NEWSPAPER

20th July, 2018

ITEM WISE EDITORIALS

29th WEEK



JEWISH NATION STATE LAW

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NEWSPAPER EDITORIALS

... DISCUSSION

20th JULY, 2018

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Dangerous law

Israel's 'nation state' law undermines its Arab minority and obstructs the peace process

The 'nation state' law passed by Israel's Parliament amid strong protests by Opposition lawmakers, has raised concerns about its commitment to peace in the region. The legislation, which will become one of Israel's powerful Basic Laws that have constitutional status, lays down that "Israel is the historic homeland of the Jewish people and they have an exclusive right to national self-determination in it". The law strips Arabic, the first language of 1.8 million citizens, of its national language status; states that Jerusalem, "whole and united", is its capital; and vows to "promote and encourage" the establishment and consolidation of Jewish settlements, which it sees as a national value. Supporters of the Bill say it is aimed to boost Israel's Jewish identity and will not discriminate against minorities. But the reality looks more complicated in Israel and the occupied territories. As it is, the Arab community, which makes up a fifth of Israel's population, faces discrimination when it comes to opportunities and rights. The Israeli right's anti-minority politics is no secret. By providing exclusive right to national self-determination only to the Jewish people and by downgrading Arabic's status, the law sends a clear message. For decades, the Israeli far-right sought Jewishness as the ethnic religious character of the state. The new Basic Law sets the stage for that transition, challenging the basic concepts of equality, which even Israel's declaration of independence promised to all its inhabitants. Arab MPs have called the legislation racist and a form of apartheid aimed at creating two systems within one country.

The emphasis on Jerusalem and the promise to promote settlements pose a direct threat to any peace process with the Palestinians. Jerusalem remains a disputed territory, with Palestinians seeing its eastern part as the capital of their future state. Israel's claim over the city remains a key point of dispute between the two sides. Besides, if Israel sees Jewish settlements as a national value and continues to promote them in the Palestinian territories, it cannot command confidence when it says it is still committed to the two-state solution. The law further erodes the credibility of Israel's professed support of an independent Palestinian state. Israel has just passed two other pieces of legislation – one places limits on Palestinians under occupation in accessing Israel's High Court, and the other bans individuals and groups seeking political action against the country or the prosecution of Israeli soldiers abroad, from entering Israeli school premises. Together, these laws allow the Israeli state to institutionalise discrimination against the minorities at home, deepen occupation in the Palestinian territories and stifle even the limited rights of the Palestinians living under occupation.

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INDIA'S NATIONAL NEWSPAPER SINCE 1878

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4 Dangerous law: on Israel's 'nation state' law

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Effect of policies and politics of developed and developing countries on India's interests, Indian diaspora.



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JEWISH NATION STATE LAW



BENJAMIN NETANYAHU



The Israel Prime Minister calls it a "decisive moment" in Israeli history.

- 1 Israel Parliament adopted a law defining the Country as the Nation State of the Jewish people.
- 2 It declares Israel as the historic homeland of the Jews, they have a "unique" right to self-determination there.
- 3 The law strips Arabic, the first language of 1.8 million citizens of its National language status.
- 4 The law states that, Jerusalem, whole and united, is its Capital.
- 5 It owes to promote and encourage the establishment and consolidation of Jewish settlements.



KNESSET

Israel has got a population of around 8 million, out of which, Arab citizens account for about 17.5%.

WHAT THE ARAB PARLIAMENT MEMBERS SAID?

- 1 They called the legislation "racist".
- 2 Arab members say that it encourages not only discrimination, but racism as well.
- 3 Some members feel it officially legalizes apartheid and legally defines Israel as an apartheid system.

But, the Government says it aims to defend Israel's status as a "Jewish and Democratic State" and in future, the courts may consider the country's Jewish nature and may lead to more "narrow interpretation of Arabs' rights".

HOW TO VIEW THIS DECISION?



- 1 Arab Community already faces discrimination, when it comes to opportunities and rights.
- 2 Israel's anti- minority politics is no secret.

- 3 By downgrading Arabic's status, it sent a clear message.
- 4 Israel's claim over the Jerusalem city is strengthened because of this law.
- 5 If Israel see Jewish's settlements as a National value and continues to promote them in the Palestine territories, it cannot command confidence, when it says it is still committed to the Two States Solution.
- 6 The law erodes the credibility of the Israel's promised support for independent Palestine State.

The law defends the occupation in the Palestine territories and stifles even the limited rights of Palestinians living under its occupation.

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FOR VIEWING THIS VIDEO

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